

Driver Qualification Files · employer playbook

For Maria Santos · Acme Trucking LLC

The carrier maintains a complete DQ file for every CDL driver per §391.51. Every missing document is a citation; missing patterns across multiple drivers is an unsatisfactory safety rating. This playbook tells you what to check, when, and who owns each piece.

I · THE CARRIER'S STANDING DUTIES

- Build the DQ file at hire** · 12 documents per §391.51 within 30 days of safety-sensitive duty start
- Maintain the file** · annual MVR, annual review, annual violation cert, medical card recerts, Clearinghouse limited query each year
- Verify the NRCME entry** for the medical examiner + document the verification date · §391.23(m)
- Confirm CDLIS shows "certified"** · the medical card on file isn't enough · state must show certified status · driver is OOS if not
- Retain the file** · duration of employment + 3 years for most items · 5 years for D&A · §391.51 + §382.401

II · THE ANNUAL MAINTENANCE CALENDAR

WHEN	TASK	CFR
Each driver's hire-anniversary month	Pull annual MVR (every state where licensed in past 12 mo) · run annual limited Clearinghouse query · conduct + sign §391.25(c) annual review	§391.25, §382.701(b)
Each driver's hire-anniversary month	Driver completes annual violation self-certification form	§391.27
60 / 30 / 7 days before med-card expiration	Reminders to driver + safety director · book the exam · receive new card + verify CDLIS	§391.45
Roadside inspection received	Add to driver file · review violations against progressive discipline matrix · DataQ challenges if appropriate	§396.9

WHEN	TASK	CFR
Any new accident	Update §390.15 Accident Register · post-accident D&A decision applied · file accident report in driver file	§390.15, §382.303
Driver termination	Retention clock starts · 3 years for most §391 items · 5 years for D&A · file move to "terminated" with retention metadata	§391.51(d)

III · COMMON FINDINGS ACROSS AUDITS

- **No NRCME verification date** · medical card is there but you never documented checking the registry · this is the single most-cited DQF finding
- **Annual review skipped** · driver's been there 2+ years with no §391.25(c) reviews on file
- **Previous-employer responses missing** · §391.23(d) inquiry attempt logs exist but the actual responses don't · investigators want the responses, not "we tried"
- **MVR pulled only from one state** · driver was licensed in 2 states in past 12 months, only one was pulled
- **ELDT certificate missing** · for any driver who got CDL after 02/07/2022 · easy to miss for in-house upgrades
- **Annual limited Clearinghouse query absent** · pre-employment full was done but the recurring annual was forgotten · §382.701(b) violation

IV · THE 5 AUDIT-DEFENSE MOVES

1. **Single source of truth** · all 12 documents per driver in one system (X3 Compass DQF tracker) · status pills make gaps visible
2. **Pre-flight check at 60 / 30 / 7 days** for everything that expires · medical, MVR, Clearinghouse, annual review
3. **Audit-export bundle** · one button generates a per-driver PDF with all 12 documents · investigator-ready
4. **Document patterns of corrective action** · not just the violation, but what you did about it · this is what auditors weigh
5. **Quarterly self-audit** · don't wait for FMCSA to find your gaps · run the audit yourself, fix what you find, document the fix

A clean DQF program isn't about more paperwork. It's about a system where every required document has a single owner, a single status, a single expiration date, and an automated reminder. The X3 Compass DQF tracker does all four.